

Colombia

Colombia is one of the richest countries in South America, with quantities of gold, emeralds, vast energy reserves, and a climate that supports two crops a year.

Emeralds

Mines near Colombia's capital, Bogotá, produce more than half the world's emeralds, which are considered the finest in the world.

Coffee

Traditionally, coffee has always been an important export for Colombia. Today, it is still one of the world's largest coffee exporters.

Resourceful lands

With massive reserves of coal, oil, and natural gas, Colombia is almost self-sufficient in energy.

Swampy rivers

The coastal regions of the Guianas are humid, swampy, and low-lying—ideal for growing rice, sugar cane, and other tropical products.

Rain forest tribes

The Yanomami are a native people of hunters and gatherers who live in enormous thatched circular huts called *yanos*.

The Guianas

The Guiana coast was colonized by the British, Dutch, and French. Former British Guiana is now independent Guyana, Dutch Guiana is now independent Suriname, while French Guiana remains as the only European colony left on the South American mainland.

Suriname

Dutch influence is still evident in the capital city, Paramaribo, which boasts many Dutch-style buildings.

This is a stylish building.

Guyana

The British took control of the country in 1814 and concentrated on growing sugar. Today, it remains famous for its Demerara sugar.

French Guiana

The European Space Agency launches its Ariane rockets from Kourou on the north coast of French Guiana.

One lump or two?

Quinoa

Quinoa—a protein-rich cereal that was important in pre-Colombian civilizations—is grown high up in the Andes. Incas called Quinoa the “mother of all seeds.”

Dance the Cumbia

Many Colombians dance the *Cumbia*—a dance based on a blend of traditions from its past cultures.

Venezuela

When Italian explorer Amerigo Vespucci first visited the area in 1499, he named the land Venezuela, or “Little Venice.” Today it is a wealthy country due to its immense oil and mineral reserves, and is very urbanized, with 90 percent of its people living in cities.

Caracas

Heavily populated, Venezuela's capital city is now a major financial and commercial center.

Mineral wealth

Venezuela has vast mineral reserves of coal, iron, bauxite, and gold.

Pearly whites

First heavily fished by the Spanish in the 1500s, the oysters of Venezuela's Pearl Coast are today greatly depleted.

The world's your oyster!

ANGEL FALLS

Can't see any falling angels.

We're rich!

Why, halo there.

I've gone to seed.

I'm full of energy.

Do I smell gas?

Do you Cumbia often?